



**Brutal bounce:** Steve Smith cops one on the back elbow as the Perth pitch bares its teeth. GETTY IMAGES

comes in. Yes, I am well aware that today some batters do advance down the pitch to the quicks, but it's more a desperate, premeditated measure than a reflex technical move. It can come off, just as it does when batters move away from the stumps or across them to play limited-overs shots. More than skill, it is luck that makes it come off, but never on a consistent basis.

So, for me, playing on a turning pitch requires more talent and footwork than playing pace. That is why, if you don't score runs on such surfaces, you are not a great batter. Since top-quality spin is seldom, if ever, seen in these countries and their pitches, the moment they see spin in the sub-continent, they get uncomfortable and question the quality of the pitch. That's typical, but unless you score in foreign conditions, how can a batter be called great?

Similarly, even if their quicks didn't get wickets on the sub-continent on pitches not conducive to pace, they would still be called great. But sub-continent spinners who failed to take five-fors on their pacy pitches, or batters who didn't score hundreds there, would not. The double standards are so glaring that they are now simply amusing.

The second Test is a few days away, and it's at the Gabba, which is considered one of the fastest pitches in Australia. Remember a Test against South Africa a few years back at the Gabba that also finished in a couple of days, with the ball flying off a length and bouncing over the keeper's head for byes. It was sheer luck that no player got seriously injured. The excuse?

The curator got it wrong by leaving a bit more grass on it, or so the world was told. Did the pitch get a poor rating? No, sir, those are reserved only for the pitches in the sub-continent.

disgrace, is sadly still believed even by the complexed ones in the sub-continent. They will rate a batter only if he scores tons on pacy, bouncy pitches, but if a batter from their part of the world doesn't get a century in the sub-continent, he will still be called great.

Having played a bit of cricket myself, I can say that batting against pace requires just two movements, forward or back. To counter spin, it is not just about playing forward or back, but also about going down the pitch to smother the turn and attack the ball. That's where skill

**Smith didn't get hit on the front elbow but the back elbow, which explains the uneven and steep bounce of the pitch. Khawaja tempered his remarks by saying the pitch tends to play a bit better over the next couple of days. That still doesn't excuse the behaviour of the pitch on day one this time.**